

99 — A vessel we wish to see arrive

Edition six posed a question, edition seven provided an answer; this edition looks at the vessel upon which we all sail. With attention, with respect for those working on board, and with the gaze of a child who can do no more than see what is truly there.

Europe is a ship. A supertanker, to be precise—hundreds of kilometres long in its institutional sense, with four hundred and fifty million people on board, and with a crew that carries out its work as it has been taught to do. The captain stands on the bridge at the rear, surrounded by instruments that promise him insight into a ship too long to overlook in a single glance. He does his best. What he sees, he weighs; what he weighs, he decides; what he decides, he transmits to the engine room. This is how a responsible human being operates within a large apparatus. No ill-will, no stupidity—rather the limitation every human knows when steering something larger than their field of vision.

But the bow is crumpling. At the front of the vessel, at a distance the wheelhouse can no longer see, the prow is already striking the quay towards which it was steered without anyone intending it so. Farmers in Friesland, Spain, Romania are disappearing. Industrial capacity in Germany is shrinking. Youth in France and Italy seek work that no longer exists. Energy is imported from places about which it has been decided that we disagree. Defence remains below a standard we promise but do not meet. Demography shifts in a direction no one explicitly desired. It is not one single crisis but a pattern—the front of the ship slowly collapsing while the crew on the bridge still believes that everything falls within normal parameters.

What a child would see

A child seeing this entire scene for the first time would not be angry with the captain. A child would look first. It would see that the captain is doing his best. It would see that the crew is working hard. It would see the engine room smoking and hear something beeping somewhere. It would see that something is happening at the front which is not visible from the bridge. And it would ask: has anyone told the captain that the bow is hitting the quay? May I do that?

That is the position from which this edition is written. Not out of anger at a failing Europe. Not out of cynicism regarding Brussels. Not from a desire to unmask or replace anyone. But from the simple observation of a spectator living in Malta, far from the European heartland, who still wishes to see the ship arrive—not because the system is dear to him, but because the people on board are dear to him. The farmer who loses his land. The worker whose factory closes. The student who sees her education eroded by rules no one understands anymore. The administrator who, within his limitations, tries to serve what has been entrusted to him. Four hundred and fifty million people, each with a home, a child, a hope. The ship must arrive, and it is worth saying so aloud.

What love means in an analysis

In European publishing culture, love is a word that does not belong in a serious piece. A journalist or analyst who writes from love is suspected of naivety, sentimentality, or a hidden ideological agenda. Therefore, most European commentators write from a different tone: scepticism, irony, critical scrutiny, professionalised distance. That has its value—distance

prevents the carousel of wishful thinking. But distance also excludes something. He who stands too far away no longer sees what is truly happening; he who does not place people in his analysis writes analyses that do not reach people.

Het Open Vizier chooses a different position. Not sentimentality, not naivety, but a foundation of reverence. Reverence for him who steers the ship, even if his field of vision limits him. Reverence for those working on board, even if they feel the crumples without being able to name them. Reverence for the quay—for the reality that is not polite but is inexorable. And reverence for the possibility that someone on the vessel still hears, still sees, still moves. From that reverence, it is possible to be sharp without becoming harsh, to be concrete without accusation, to propose without demanding.

What follows in this edition

Twelve instalments, in four parts. In the first part, we look at the ship in side profile: how it was built, why the captain can no longer see the front, and what he sees through windows that are not clear but reflect back to him through various layers of distortion. In the second part, we open the holds: eight compartments in which the European cargo is carried, four already crumpled, four still standing. We look at what lies in each compartment—not as written-off sectors but as places where people work and hope. In the third part, we look at a second wheelhouse: not to replace the captain, but to help him with what he cannot see. Who would stand there, how would it work, who would pilot from which continent. And in the fourth part, we look at the reader: where you yourself stand on board, what your role is, what an act stemming from love for the ship and its people would mean for you.

A conclusion before it begins

We know that a ship larger than the eye can oversee is not saved by a single spectator. We know that the six obstacles—limited perception, vested interests, short time horizons, dilution of scale, attachment to identity, and the temptation of despair—run deeper than twelve instalments can resolve. We know that Het Open Vizier is but one voice, from Malta, for those who listen. What we do not know, and what keeps us in motion, is what someone somewhere in Wageningen, Brussels, Madrid, Lyon, Berlin, or Warsaw will do with this edition. Perhaps nothing. Perhaps something small. Perhaps something that will be remembered years from now as the moment when it was first asked aloud whether the captain could still see the front.

Regardless—the ship sails on. We sincerely wish it to arrive. Not for ourselves, not for the system, not for history—but for the farmers, the workers, the students, the children, the elderly, the entrepreneurs, and the civil servants who did not choose to live in this Europe at this time, but were given this place to lead their lives. For them we write, with love and respect, and with a gaze childlike enough to see what is truly there.

Edition eight begins here.

Malta, August 2026